

Potential Research Topics: Suburbia & its Discontents

Below you will find a short list of possible **topic areas** that could lead to specific research projects for WR 60. Try running a basic search for any of these topic areas that catches your interest, and also **be sure to: try Google News**; search your topic through the UCI Libraries search and academic databases; and look through physical shelves in the library. Book chapters, scholarly essays, major news weeklies, and newspapers of record are all pertinent resources. Use the UCI Libraries WR 60 Research Guide.

Keep in mind that many of these topic areas have updated information in the news regularly. It is up to you to make sure that the problem is still current.

Topic	Articles in popular venues →
'The Octopus': problems of developer monopolies, 'public-private' schemes, corruption, developer and landlord campaign finance and lobbying, real estate speculation, unregulated rental markets and price-gouging, and resultant problems of unaffordability, etc.	The Growth Machine and Its Discontents (LA Times) Alyssa Katz, <i>Our Lot</i> (2009) Mike Davis, "Power Lines," <i>City of Quartz</i> ('06)
'Privatopia': problems of HOAs, toll roads and toll lanes, cuts to public services, 'secession from the city,' etc.	Evan McKenzie, <i>Privatopia</i> (1994)
'Fortress America': problems of gated communities, security/surveillance, housing discrimination, exclusion, hostile architecture, hostility against the poor, etc.	'They Just Don't Fit In' (Guardian) Setha Low, <i>Behind the Gates</i> (2006) Mike Davis, "Fortress LA," <i>City of Quartz</i> ('06)
'Suburban Panics and Suburban Warriors': problems of NIMBYism, the far right (including the rise of the New Right), anti-immigrant policy and racist vigilantism, anti-gay movements, and other forms of cultural exclusion, fear, xenophobia, and racism	Suburban Radicals (LA Times) Right-Wing Pretexts (Nation) OC's far right has usurped the American flag (LA Times) Justin Chacón, <i>No One Is Illegal</i> (2006) Daniel Martinez HoSang, <i>Racial Propositions</i> , esp "They Keep Coming!" (2010) Lisa McGirr, <i>Suburban Warriors</i> (2015)
'Land Laid Waste': problems of habitat destruction (especially development in wetland, hillside/canyon, and floodplain areas), pollution, open/recreational space inequality, etc.	Residents protest Irvine Company plan (OC Register) Adam Rome, <i>The Bulldozer in the Countryside</i> (2001)
'Asphalt Nation': problems of auto-dependency, impermeable surfaces, congestion, transit, etc	Asphalt Nation (New York Times) Anthony Downs, <i>Still Stuck in Traffic</i> (2005)
'The Carceral State': problems of policing, sentencing, jails, immigration enforcement and detention, hostile architecture and barricaded	Dolores Canales fights for an end to solitary confinement (LA Times)

streets, street sweeps and anti-homeless law, policy, and harassment, etc.	Orange County Sherriff's cooperation with ICE sees spike in inmate transfers (LA Times) Mike Davis, "The Hammer and the Rock," <i>City of Quartz</i> (2006) Ruth Wilson Gilmore, <i>Golden Gulag</i> (2007) Michelle Alexander, <i>The New Jim Crow</i> (2010)
"There Will Be Blood": problems of economic inequality, the repression of labor and other forms of organizing, etc.	How one election changed Disney's relationship with its hometown (LA Times) Why University of California Workers Stopped Their Historic Strike (Nation) What day laborers are hired to do (LA Times) Howard Zinn, <i>A People's History of the United States</i> (2003) Juan de Lara, <i>Inland Shift</i> (2018)

You are certainly not restricted to these topics, but you must meet with me for approval of any topic not listed here.

Below, find a list of recommended scholarly books.

The sister book of one of our course texts:

Laura Pulido, Laura Barraclough, and Wendy Cheng, *A People's Guide to Los Angeles* (2012)

Urban Studies approaches:

Mark Gottdiener, *Planned Sprawl: Private & Public Interests in Suburbia* (1977)

Joel Garreau, *Edge City: Life on the New Frontier* (1992), especially "Southern California: Community"

Richard Longstreth, *City Center to Regional Mall: Architecture, the Automobile, and Retailing in Los Angeles, 1920-1950* (1997) and *The Drive-In, the Supermarket, and the Transformation of Commercial Space in Los Angeles, 1914-1941* (1999)

Roberta Grantz and Norman Mintz, *Cities Back from the Edge: New Life for Downtown* (1998)

Jane Kay, *Asphalt Nation: How the Automobile Took Over America & How We Can Take It Back* (1998)

Michael Weiss, [The Clustered World](#): *How We Live, What We Buy, & What It All Means About Who We Are* (2000)

Adam Rome, *The Bulldozer in the Countryside: Suburban Sprawl & the Rise of American Environmentalism* (2001)

Oliver Gillham, *The Limitless City: A Primer on the Urban Sprawl Debate* (2002)

Myron Orfield, *American Metropolitcs: The New Suburban Reality* (2002)

Gergory Squires, *Urban Sprawl: causes, consequences, & policy responses* (2002)

Robert Lang, *Edgeless City: Exploring the Elusive Metropolis* (2003)

Dolores Hayden, *Building Suburbia: Green Fields and Urban Growth, 1820-2000* (2003)

Anthony Downs, *Still Stuck in Traffic: Coping with Peak-Hour Traffic Congestion* (2005)

Ann Forsyth, *Reforming Suburbia: The Planned Communities of Irvine, Columbia, and The Woodlands* (2005), especially the case study chapter "The Irvine Ranch" and general chapters 1 and 5-7.

Joanna Cagan and Neil deMause, *Field of Schemes: How the Great Stadium Swindle Turns Public Money into Private Profit* (2008)

Andrés Duany, Elizabeth Plater-Zyberg, and Jeff Speck, *Suburban Nation: The Rise of Sprawl and the*

Decline of the American Dream (2010)

American Studies approaches:

topic: problems of suburbia

Eric Schlosser, [*Fast Food Nation: The Dark Side of the All-American Meal*](#) (2001)

Alyssa Katz, [*Our Lot: How Real Estate Came to Own Us*](#) (2009)

Nancy Duncan and James Duncan, *The Landscapes of Privilege: The Politics of the Aesthetic in an American Suburb* (2004)

Matthew Lasner, *High Life: Condo Living in the Suburban Century* (2023), especially “Leisure Worlds” and “California Townhouses.”

Setha Low, *Behind the Gates: Life, Security, and the Pursuit of Happiness in Fortress America* (2004)

Kyle Riismandel, *Neighborhood of Fear: The Suburban Crisis in American Culture, 1975-2001* (2020)

topic: Southern California and the Right

Natalie Petrzela, *Classroom Wars: Language, Sex, and the Making of Modern Political Culture* (2015), especially “Family Life and Sex Education and the Unmaking of Anaheim's ‘Golden Age.’”

Eric Avila, *Popular Culture in the Age of White Flight: Fear and Fantasy in Suburban Los Angeles* (2006).

Lisa McGirr, *Suburban Warriors: The Origins of the New American Right* (2015)

Michelle Nickerson, *Mothers of Conservatism: Women and the Postwar Right* (2012)

Darren Dochuk, *From Bible Belt to Sun Belt: Plain-Folk Religion, Grassroots Politics, and the Rise of Evangelical Conservatism* (2010)

Tanya Erzen, *Straight to Jesus: Sexual and Christian Conversions in the Ex-Gay Movement* (2006)

Daniel Martinez HoSang, *Racial Propositions: Ballot Initiatives and the Making of Postwar California* (2010), especially “‘They Keep Coming!’ The Tangled Roots of Proposition 187.”

Justin Akers Chacón and Mike Davis, *No One is Illegal*, especially chapters 24-25, 27-29 (2006)

topic: immigrant communities and the ethnoburb

Charlotte Brooks, *Alien Neighbors, Foreign Friends: Asian Americans, housing, and the transformation of urban California* (2009)

Karin Aguilar-San Juan, *Little Saigons: Staying Vietnamese in America* (2009)

Phuong Tran Nguyen, *Becoming Refugee American* (2017)

Willow S Lung-Amam, *Trespassers? Asian American and the Battle for Suburbia* (2017)

Russell Shoho, *From the Battlefields to the Homefront: The Kazuo Masuda Legacy* (2009)

Wendy Cheng, *The Changs Next Door to the Días: Remapping Race in Suburban California* (2013)

Mae Ngai, *Impossible Subjects: Illegal Aliens and the Making of Modern America* (2014)

Juan de Lara, *Inland Shift: Race, Space, and Capital in Southern California* (2018)

Genevieve Carpio, *Collisions at the Crossroads: How Place and Mobility Make Race* (2019)

Carribean Fragoza, Romeo Guzmán, Cummings, and Reft, *East of East: The Making of Greater El Monte* (2020)

topic: labor history

Gilbert González, *Labor & Community: Mexican Citrus Worker Villages in a Southern California County, 1900-1950* (1994)

Douglas Sackman, *Orange Empire: California and the Fruits of Eden* (2007)

Richard Street, *Beasts of the Field: A Narrative History of California Farmworkers, 1769-1913* (2004)

topic: the local environment, environmental history, environmental polemic:

Richard Lillard, [*Eden in Jeopardy: Man's Prodigal Meddling with the Environment*](#) (1966)
Jared Farmer, [*Trees in Paradise: A California History*](#) (2013)
Patrick Mitchell, *Santa Ana River Guide: From Crest to Coast* (2006)

a groundwork of Southern California studies:

Louis Adamic, "Los Angeles! There She Blows!" *Outlook* (1930); *Dynamite: The Story of Class Violence in America* (1931); *Laughing in the Jungle: The Autobiography of an Immigrant in America* (1932)
Morrow Mayo, *Los Angeles* (1933)
Carey McWilliams, *Factories in the Field: The Story of Migratory Farm Labor in California* (1939), *Southern California Country: An Island on the Land* (1946), *California: The Great Exception* (1949), *North from Mexico: The Spanish-Speaking People of the US* (1949)

the 'LA School' of political and social analysis:

Robert B Gottlieb (and various co-authors), *Empires in the Sun* (1985); *A Life of its Own* (1988); *War on Waste* (1989); *Forcing the Spring* (1993); *Reducing Toxics* (1995); *Environmentalism Unbound* (2001); *The Next Los Angeles* (2005); *Reinventing Los Angeles* (2007); *Food Justice* (2010); *Global Cities* (2017); *Thirst for Growth* (2022); *Care Politics* (2022)
Allen J Scott, *Metropolis: From the Division of Labor to Urban Form* (1988); *Technopolis* (1993); *The Cultural Economy of Cities* (2000); *On Hollywood: The Place, the Industry* (2005)
Edward Soja, *The City: Los Angeles and Urban Theory at the End of the Twentieth Century* (1996); *Thirdspace: Journeys to Los Angeles and Other Real-and-Imagined Places* (1996); *My Los Angeles: From Urban Restructuring to Regional Urbanization* (2014)
Juan de Lara, *Inland Shift: Race, Space, and Capital in Southern California* (2018)

misc:

Robert Venturi, Denise Brown, and Steven Izenour, *Learning from Las Vegas* (1972)
Allan Sekula, "Photo-Works," *Photography Against the Grain* (1984)
Larry Strawther, *A Brief History of Los Alamitos—Rossmoor* (2012)
Stephen O'Neil, *The Acjachemen (Juaneño) Indians of Coastal Southern California* (2014)